



FINE LIVING

AUTO

Buying a convertible in Mumbai is an act of optimism, rather like wearing suede shoes in the monsoon. Yet the BMW M440i xDrive Convertible makes the argument with uncommon charm. The 4 Series Convertible returned to a fabric roof with this generation in 2020, shedding the folding metal arrangement of its predecessor. The current facelift adds sharper lights without toning down that vast, opinion-splitting grille. The roof performs its 18-second disappearing act at speeds of up to 50kmph, which proved handy while threading through the city during Ganpati. One moment we were enclosed in a handsome, if rather serious, BMW; the next, Mumbai's illuminated pandals, festoons and colour had become our ceiling. My one-year-old son looked up from the back seat, eyes widened by the Ganpati lights overhead, and suddenly the M440i's purpose felt less about showing off and more about opening the world.

There is serious machinery beneath the theatre. The 2,998cc turbocharged straight-six produces 374hp, dispatched through BMW's rear-biased xDrive system and a superb eight-speed ZF automatic. BMW claims 0–100kph in 4.9 seconds, a figure the car seems almost mischievously capable of bettering. The more useful number in Mumbai, however, is Comfort mode. With its adaptive dampers relaxed, the M440i rounds off broken surfaces with the composure of a luxury saloon, its steering light but precise and its powertrain smooth enough to tolerate festival traffic without sulking. When the traffic thins, Sport Plus reveals the M440i's more impatient side. The accelerator feels keener, the gearbox holds each ratio with greater purpose and the straight-six delivers its performance in one long, velvety surge. Its 1,890kg kerb weight becomes apparent during quick changes of direction, while the steering filters out more detail than an enthusiast might like. Even so, the car remains impressively balanced, with very little of the looseness or body shudder that sometimes betrays a convertible over broken tarmac.

The cabin is beautifully made and the sports seats are excellent, but it lacks the sense of occasion promised by the bodywork. A crisp 12.3-inch instrument display meets a 14.9-inch touchscreen, although simple functions can disappear into BMW's thicket of menus; thankfully, the iDrive rotary controller survives. The rear seats are useful rather than token, ideal for a child and tolerable for average-sized adults, but their upright backs discourage long journeys. The nominal 385-litre boot is compromised by the roof housing, and there is only a puncture-repair kit. Then there is the ₹1.09 crore ex-showroom price and the reality that Mumbai offers dust, heat, rain and horns in abundance. None of that quite defeats the M440i.

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SPECIFICATIONS

Engine
2,998 cc, turbocharged inline-six petrol with 48V mild-hybrid assistance
Power
374 bhp
Torque
500 Nm
Transmission
8-speed Steptronic Sport automatic with xDrive all-wheel drive
0–100 kmph
4.9 seconds
Top speed
250 kmph
Price
₹1.09 crore, ex-showroom

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